STATE SCAN

BIHAR: FRONTMAN & THE FIRST-TIME VOTER *PG 16*

ODISHA: MEND IT LIKE MAJHI *PG 19*



CHESS PEACE Maharashtra CM Fadnavis with deputy CM Shinde

MANDAR DEODHAR

▶ MAHARASHTRA

THE COLD WAR IN THE MAHAYUTI

As Fadnavis cuts a seething Shinde down to size, the Mahayuti's cold war comes to boiling point

By **Dhaval S. Kulkarni**

IT'S STILL SHORT OF OPEN WARFARE, but the trenches around those Deccan forts are all lit up by stray cannonballs—some even hint it's friendly fire. The ruling Mahayuti hadn't ever been a happy ménage a trois that went waltzing into a honeymoon after its historic mandate in the 2024 assembly polls. But the tacit animus, especially centred around a sulking Eknath Shinde, is now getting explicit.

One signal came via an absence, a pointedly conspicuous one. In mid-August, the deputy CM and party colleague Bharatseth Gogawale sat out a state cabinet meeting. As the month wound down, the air thickened again, this time with a presence: that of Manoj Jarange-Patil at Mumbai's Azad Maidan. The Maratha activist's now-on, now-off agitations had appeared mysteriously at critical moments. His siege ended on September 2, but only with a qualified victory. However, the state government's acceptance of Jarange-Patil's demand of Kunbi status for Marathas of Marathwada has miffed NCP cabinet minister and OBC leader Chhagan Bhujbal, who boycotted a cabinet meeting on September 3 as OBC protests erupted across the state.

Gogawale's triggers are, of course, not mysterious. The four-term Mahad MLA, minister for employment guarantees, and fellow Sainik and education minister Dadaji Bhuse have long coveted the guardian ministership of Raigad and Nashik districts, respectively. In January, when Aditi Tatkare, the women and child development minister from Ajit Pawar's NCP, and water resources minister Girish Mahajan (BJP) were named to the posts, vociferous Sena protests forced a retreat. The posts—